UX WRITING & RESEARCH · CASE STUDY

BudgetNest: Better Financial Habits Through Empathy and UX

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1. Introduction: From Wallet Woes to UX Wins

If you told me five years ago that I'd be pouring hours into designing a financial literacy tool, I probably would've laughed (politely) and changed the subject. I was the girl who could help someone else budget for a wedding but couldn't explain where her own money disappeared to by the 15th of every month.

Then I discovered books like Secrets of the Millionaire Mind, The Richest Man in Babylon, and The Psychology of Money — and I was hooked. I began to realize that personal finance isn't just about numbers. It's about feelings, habits, and systems. Most people aren't financially irresponsible; they're just overwhelmed, under-informed, and underserved.

BudgetNest is my attempt to bridge that gap. It's a self-initiated UX project designed for young adults across Africa, the diaspora, and beyond who want to manage their money but feel like budgeting apps either talk down to them or talk in circles.

This case study is a walkthrough of how I:

- Researched and validated the problem

- Designed for emotional intelligence

- Wrote microcopy that talks to users, not at them

- Translated data into motivation

- Crafted a simple but behaviorally effective user journey

2. The Problem: Money Is Emotional, Not Just Math

- Tolu, a fresh graduate in Nigeria earning just enough to survive. At the end of every month, she has no clue where her salary went.

- Jacob, a self-employed creative in South Africa juggling multiple income streams but never really tracking any of them. He just wants to stop feeling anxious every time he checks his account balance.

- Tasha, a diaspora-based young professional working remotely in the UK. She's trying to send money home, save for travel, and still afford brunch.

- Marcus, a Canadian engineer with ADHD who finds most budgeting tools too cluttered and overwhelming. He just wants clarity and calm.

- Anita, a 35-year-old US-based single mom balancing child expenses, student loans, and multiple jobs.

They’re not clueless. They’re just tired of apps that assume everyone loves pie charts and spreadsheets. They want:

- Gentle guidance, not judgment

- Visual, bite-sized lessons

- Tools that reflect their reality (multiple income types, informal saving styles, varying currencies)

Most budgeting apps overcomplicate or oversimplify. BudgetNest aims for the sweet spot: human-first, clear, and emotionally intelligent.

3. Research: Listening Before Writing

Methods:

- 12 one-on-one interviews across Nigeria, Ghana, and UK (ages 20-35)

- 3 focus groups of remote workers, undergrads, and freelancers

- Surveys: 100+ responses via Google Forms from users in 4 countries

- Competitor analysis: Mint, YNAB, Piggyvest, Emma, and Cleo

Insights:

- 70% don’t track spending consistently

- 55% use WhatsApp or mental notes to manage money

- 89% said they want to budget but feel overwhelmed

- People feel guilt or shame after spending and want apps that encourage, not scold

Direct Quotes:

> *"I want something that feels like a friend who’s good with money. Not a finance bro."*

"I tried budgeting before but it felt like punishment."

These insights helped shape every design and copy decision.

4. Competitive Analysis: What We're Up Against

To design something useful and humane, I needed to first understand what users were already trying — and why they were giving up. I evaluated six key players: Mint, YNAB, Piggyvest, Emma, Cleo, and Revolut, and compared their features, UX tone, and emotional resonance.

> *---------- App Strengths Flaws That Alienate Users ---------- ---------- ---------- Mint Robust analytics, The UI is information-dense and automatic visually chaotic — great for finance categorization, nerds, but overwhelming for everyday bill tracking users. It also assumes U.S.-based bills, banks, and financial culture, making it unintuitive for global users.*

> *YNAB (You Need A Clear methodology, The steep learning curve and fixed Budget) proactive structure alienate users with budgeting irregular income (like freelancers philosophy or side hustlers). It also uses rigid, rule-heavy language that often feels paternalistic — not great for users already feeling ashamed or behind.*

> *Piggyvest Simple savings Offers little in terms of actual tools, culturally budgeting or financial education. relevant for There's almost no in-app guidance or Nigerians, light reflection of real-world complexity UI (like irregular cash flow, multiple currencies, or emotional triggers). It's functional, but not emotionally intelligent.*

> *Cleo Witty chatbot, Gen While engaging, Cleo often feels Z-focused tone, like a gimmick — more meme than fun microcopy money mentor. There's little long-term behavior support, and users who are actually stressed financially may feel dismissed or mocked by the jokey tone.*

> *Emma Modern UI, Focuses heavily on alerting users excellent after things go wrong (e.g., fees, subscription overspending), not on helping them tracking plan ahead. Its tone is neutral-bordering-cold, lacking emotional warmth or behavioral psychology cues.*

> *Revolut Great for Built for travel and transfers — not multi-currency personal budgeting. It's slick, but support and not sensitive. No real attempt to financial tools connect to user goals, habits, or mental load. Great at transactions, weak at transformation. ---------- ----------*

What These Gaps Taught Me

Rather than trying to do everything better, I chose to do a few things with more empathy:

- BudgetNest avoids "finance-splaining": Unlike apps like YNAB or Mint, which expect users to learn their philosophy or interface before seeing results, BudgetNest guides users gently, starting with wins and habits they already use — even if that’s just writing expenses in WhatsApp.

- We normalize emotional spending patterns. Where Emma and Revolut stick to cold facts, BudgetNest uses microcopy and nudges that validate feelings like guilt, stress, or even spending to self-soothe — and offers healthier alternatives without judgment.

- We’re built for irregular income. Many apps assume salaried workers with consistent biweekly pay. But for freelancers, remote workers, or side hustlers, income flows unpredictably. BudgetNest allows flexible income entries, “safe-to-spend” guidance, and soft goal suggestions that adapt to their rhythm.

- Microcopy as a form of care. Cleo’s humor works for some, but flops for users in financial distress. BudgetNest uses thoughtful, clear, and warm copy — because tone can either relieve shame or reinforce it.

- Simplicity with substance. Piggyvest’s clean design is good — but minimal features leave users stuck when real life hits. BudgetNest maintains a clean UI while offering actual behavior-shifting tools, like guilt-free summaries and adaptive nudges.

5. Personas: Meet the Heart of BudgetNest

Tolu — The Determined Newbie

> **Age:** 24
> **Location:** Lagos, Nigeria
> **Occupation:** NYSC/Entry-level Admin Assistant
> **Tech comfort:** Beginner
> **Goal:** Learn how to manage her first salary and avoid falling into debt. Needs simple language, gentle nudges, and relatable encouragement.

Jacob — The Freelance Juggler

> **Age:** 30
> **Location:** Cape Town, South Africa
> **Occupation:** Freelance Graphic Designer with irregular income

> **Tech comfort:** Moderate
> **Goal:** Stay on top of income from different clients, track business expenses, and build savings without stress. Needs flexibility and custom categories.

Tasha — The Diaspora Balancer

> **Age:** 29
> **Location:** Manchester, UK
> **Occupation:** Remote Customer Success Rep
> **Tech comfort:** High
> **Goal:** Save, invest, and support family back in Ghana without feeling stretched. Needs currency switching, smart budgeting, and easy reports.

Marcus — The Clarity Seeker

> **Age:** 32
> **Location:** Toronto, Canada
> **Occupation:** Software Engineer with ADHD
> **Tech comfort:** Very High
> **Goal:** Use a clean, quiet space to track finances. Needs an uncluttered UI, minimal notifications, and personalized reminders that don't overwhelm.

Anita — The Resilient Provider

> **Age:** 35
> **Location:** Atlanta, USA
> **Occupation:** Single Mom, Teacher & Uber Driver
> **Tech comfort:** Moderate
> **Goal:** Save consistently, manage debt, and teach her teenage son budgeting. Needs visual tools, joint goals, and emotional validation.

These personas became my north stars. Every feature had to answer: Would this help Tolu feel empowered? Would Jacob find it flexible? Would Tasha feel in control? Would Marcus feel calm? Would Anita feel supported?

6. Core App Features

1. Smart Expense Tracker

Categorizes expenses automatically and visualizes daily, weekly, and monthly spending patterns in intuitive charts.

2. Interactive Savings Goals

Users can create named goals like “Travel Fund” or “New Laptop,” with milestone celebrations and visual progress indicators.

3. Budget Planner Assistant

A chatbot-style feature that walks users through setting up realistic monthly budgets and suggests tweaks based on their patterns.

4. Personalized Nudges

Behavioral prompts like: “You’ve spent ₦5,000 more on eating out this week—want to set a soft limit?” These are optional, friendly, and never guilt-inducing.

5. Financial Knowledge Bites

Short, scrollable lessons (2–3 minutes) on topics like inflation, emergency funds, compound interest, and saving on a low income.

6. Mood Check-ins

Users can log how they feel about their spending and savings. This data helps personalize the tone of future nudges and tips.

7. Daily and Weekly Reflections

Gentle prompts that encourage users to review what worked and what didn’t, without judgment. E.g.: “What was one thing you did this week that helped you save more?”

8. Customizable Notifications

Let users choose the tone, frequency, and type of financial prompts they want. From playful to professional.

9. Offline Mode & Data Light UI

For accessibility in low-connectivity regions, BudgetNest can be used offline with auto-sync when reconnected.

10. Community Challenges (Beta Feature)

Gamified challenges like “₦500 a Day Save Streak” with progress boards, encouraging accountability and fun.

7. User Journey: From Overwhelmed to In Control

1. Onboarding A warm, friendly setup asking about income types, priorities, and habits. "Hi Tolu 👋 Let’s build a money system that works for you."

2. Dashboard Snapshot view of income, expenses, goals, and savings progress. "You’re doing great. You’ve saved ₦50,000 towards your Rent Goal!"

3. Spend Tracker Categorizes expenses automatically with emoji-based tags. Food: ₦9,500 | Rent: ₦20,000 | Self-Care: ₦3,000

4. Savings Goals Create visual, interactive jars for dreams like “Travel Fund,” “Emergency,” or “Laptop Upgrade." "You’re 70% closer to your Travel Jar. Two more weeks at this pace and it’s yours!"

5. Knowledge Bites Quick, 3-minute lessons on practical finance. "How to Budget on Irregular Income" "The 50/30/20 Rule (For Real Humans)"

6. Nudges & Notifications Custom reminders to keep users aware, not anxious. "Heads up: You spent more on delivery this week. Want to set a soft limit?"

7. Reflect & Reset Monthly reflections help users celebrate wins and adjust plans. "You crushed your goals in March! Want to roll over that momentum into April?"

8. UX Writing: Empathy Meets Clarity

My tone goal: encouraging, friendly, and realistic. Think big sister who’s good with money, not a banker with a checklist.

Onboarding Microcopy:

> *"Tell us how you earn. Salary? Side hustle? Dollars from clients? We got you."*

Empty State:

"No expenses here yet. That’s okay. We’re starting fresh together."

Error Message:

> *"Oops! Something went wrong. Not your fault. Try again in a sec or let us know."*

Goal Encouragement:

> *"Look at you! Your Emergency Fund is 80% full. Adulting looks good on you."*

Nudges:

"Your wallet says slow down on snacks. Set a snack limit?"

9. Information Architecture & Content Strategy

- Top-Level Navigation: Dashboard | Track | Goals | Learn | Profile

- Visual Hierarchy: Progress first, numbers second

- Behavioral Design: Used positive reinforcement to drive consistency

- Localization: Currency symbol adjusts by location

- Accessibility: Color contrast, alt text, and emoji pairing for clarity

10. Challenges & Solutions

Challenge 1: Translating complex finance terms

- Solution: Broke it into visuals + analogies

> *"Compound interest is like a snowball rolling downhill. The longer it rolls, the bigger it gets."*

Challenge 2: Irregular income patterns

- Solution: Users could log multiple income types with date flexibility

Challenge 3: User guilt and shame

- Solution: Reframed overspending moments as learning points, not failures

11. Testing & Feedback

I tested a Figma prototype with 15 diverse users.

Results:

- 13/15 said it felt more human than other budgeting tools they'd tried

- 12/15 said they would recommend it to friends

- Users praised the tone, nudges, and goal-tracking interface

12. What I Would Tell a Developer or Designer

- Designers: Let’s make every number feel earned, not just shown. The layout should feel like checking in with a coach, not opening a spreadsheet.

- Developers: The nudge logic should trigger based on user behavior, but never feel punitive. We’re designing for motivation, not fear.

13. Final Reflection

BudgetNest isn’t just a UX project. It’s a product of empathy, observation, and personal transformation. It reflects what I believe great UX should do: meet users where they are, speak their language, and make life just a little easier.

If this project helps one person stop dreading payday or finally start an emergency fund, then it’s done its job.